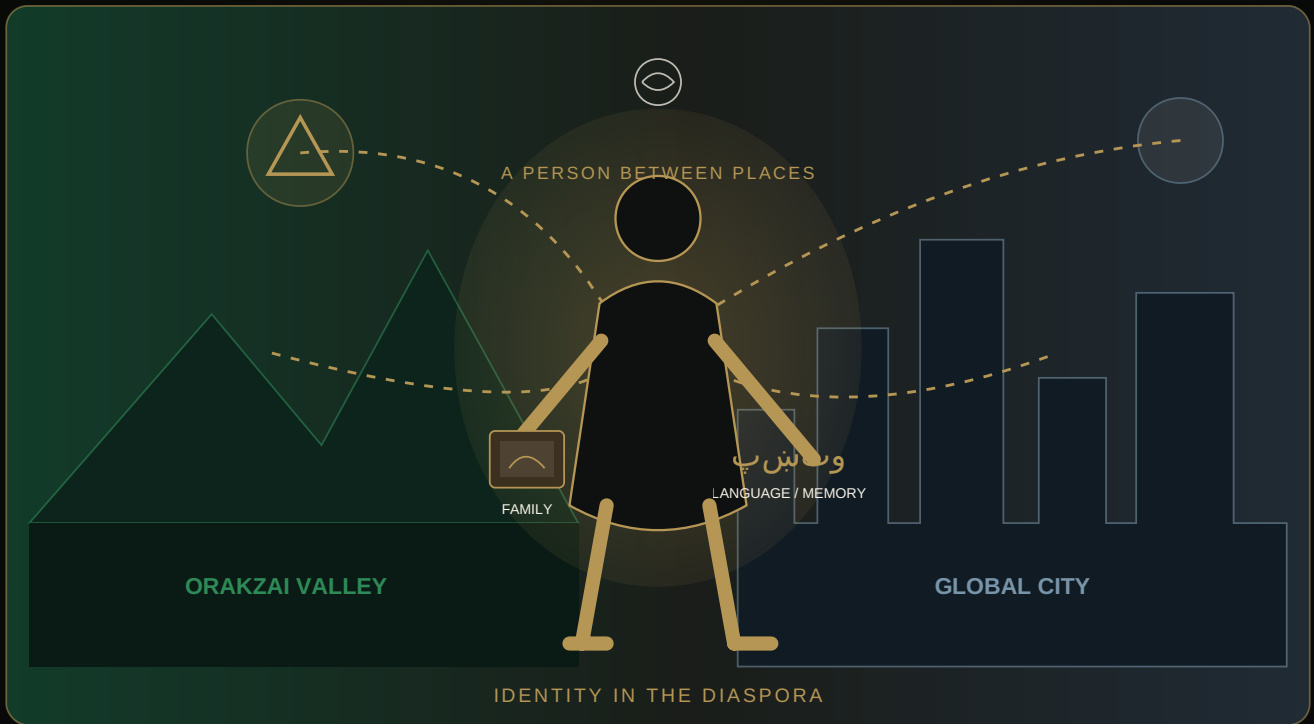


IDENTITY IN THE DIASPORA

“Between homeland, memory and the place called home.”



Between homeland, memory, and the place called home, diaspora identity can be layered, personal, and changing.



CONCEPTUAL RELATIONSHIP — NOT A DETERMINISTIC FORMULA

Identity may be shaped by many relationships and experiences; this diagram does not define any individual.



Individuals can carry several identities simultaneously, but only the person can describe which layers matter most.

Identity can travel.

It can cross a border without disappearing.

A person may be born in one country, raised in another, speak several languages, follow the traditions of their family, and still feel connected to a place they know partly through stories.

For someone from an Orakzai family, identity may include many layers: Orakzai, Pashtun, Pakistani, Muslim, British, American, Canadian, Australian, or simply the identity of the city they now call home. These identities do not always compete. Sometimes they overlap. Sometimes they change in importance. Sometimes they create questions. And sometimes identity becomes strongest when distance makes people ask where they came from.

The diaspora therefore does not create one new identity. It creates many ways of being connected.

WHAT IS IDENTITY?

Identity is not only a name, passport, language, religion, ethnicity, tribe, or nationality. It can also involve family, memory, place, relationships, values, education, profession, community, personal choices, and experience. A label may be important in one setting and less important in another. The purpose of this page is not to define individuals from outside, but to show how several dimensions can interact.

Orakzai identity may refer to ancestry, family connection, tribal affiliation, homeland connection, and cultural memory. That description is a field of possibilities, not a test. Some people may emphasize family, tribe, Pashtun identity, Pakistani identity, religious identity, local identity, professional identity, or a combination. Self-identification remains essential.

PASHTUN, PAKISTANI, AND RELIGIOUS IDENTITY

Orakzai identity can sit within a broader Pashtun cultural and linguistic world without being erased by it. Nichols's history describes Pashtun mobility across regions and changing political structures, but its Pashtun-wide scope must not be converted into an Orakzai diaspora statistic.¹ Being Pashtun does not remove more specific tribal, family, or local identities, and being Orakzai does not mean that every person has identical practices.

Pakistani identity is a national category, not a synonym for tribal identity. Religious identity is also distinct, even where faith and community life overlap. Mosque participation, Eid, Ramadan, family practice, and religious education may be important to some families, but no single hierarchy of tribe, ethnicity, nation, religion, and locality can be imposed on everyone.

HOME, HOMELAND, AND MEMORY

For diaspora families, homeland may mean a place of origin, an ancestral village, mountains, family property, grandparents, language, stories, religious memory, family graves, weddings, summer visits, or childhood memories. Another person may experience homeland mainly through a photograph, a name, a story, or a relative's voice. Home is where life happens; homeland may be a place of origin or emotional connection. They can overlap, but home is not always homeland.

LANGUAGE AND IDENTITY

Language can be a site of belonging, memory, safety, recognition, and family negotiation. A 2026 study of a migrant Pashto community in Lahore found Pashto preferred in home and community domains while Urdu and English carried utility, social mobility, and opportunity functions.² The study is broader migrant-Pashto evidence, not direct Orakzai diaspora evidence. It supports a careful point: Pashto maintenance, mixed-language use,

Memory is not a census. It is a relationship between story, photograph, name, place, voice, and interpretation. A grandparent may transmit family history, village names, genealogy, language, customs, and migration history, but not every elder has the same role, and younger people may also reinterpret or teach the past.

passive understanding, shift, loss, and revival can all be possible patterns.

Pashto may coexist with Urdu, English, French, Italian, Arabic, or another host-country language. Code-switching can represent competence and adaptation; it is not automatically cultural decline.

Language can weaken across generations because of school language, peers, urbanization, mixed-language households, media, literacy, or family choices, but loss is not inevitable. Classes, children's books, online lessons, music, poetry, archives, and conversation can support revival.

VISIBLE CULTURE AND EVERYDAY PRACTICE

Food, music, clothing, poetry, dance, Eid, weddings, funerals, and hospitality can become visible or recurring identity practices. They may be continued, adapted, translated, shortened, combined with host-country practices, or practiced privately. A particular dish, performance, garment, or celebration should not be called universally Orakzai without direct

GENERATIONS AND NEGOTIATED BELONGING

The second generation may combine parents' memories with children's own experience of school, friends, language, media, religion, and citizenship. The third generation may encounter Orakzai through ancestry, family stories, photographs, visits, and personal choice. A study of three generations of British Pakistani Muslims reports active negotiation of

evidence. Pashtun-wide cultural forms, regional practices, and Orakzai-specific evidence must remain separate. Eid may reinforce family, faith, community, memory, and intergenerational connection, but it is not uniquely Orakzai. Weddings can connect relatives across Pakistan, the Gulf, Europe, North America, and other destinations. Funerals may reconnect families with religious communities, elders, homeland, and memory. These are possible functions, not universal descriptions of every family.

religious and ethnic identity and shows that younger generations can influence older generations; this is British Pakistani evidence, not direct Orakzai evidence.³ Birthplace alone does not determine cultural identity. Youth may negotiate heritage through social media, education, sports, music, fashion, technology, career, and friendships. Women and men may experience family, education, work, religious life, community organizations, and cultural expectations differently; no single gendered pattern should be assumed.

PROFESSION, EDUCATION, AND HOST SOCIETY

Migration can add professional identity without replacing heritage: an Orakzai person may also be an engineer, doctor, teacher, entrepreneur, researcher, artist, or another professional. Schools and universities influence how young people understand language, religion, nationality, and history, but education does not necessarily weaken cultural identity. Host-country identity can be genuine and

DIGITAL IDENTITY, PRESERVATION, AND AI

WhatsApp, Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, X, and other online communities can carry Pashto content, family communication, Eid greetings, cultural videos, music, poetry, history, community news, and oral histories. Online identity may emphasize some aspects of a person more than others; social media is not a complete portrait of anyone. Photographs, family videos, audio recordings, documents, genealogies, and

simultaneous with Orakzai, Pashtun, Pakistani, or religious identity.

Urban environments create new social identities through work, education, multicultural neighborhoods, professional networks, mobility, and technology. A city may be a place of belonging without containing an identical or formally documented Orakzai community. Page 98 identified global community formation as a research gap; Page 99 asks how individuals experience that belonging.

oral histories can move from private memory into a digital archive, but consent and privacy are essential. AI can support translation, transcription, search, OCR, metadata, and language tools. It must not decide who is Orakzai, who belongs to a tribe, which genealogy is correct, which tradition is authentic, or whose identity is legitimate.

VISITS, RETURN, AND THE FEELING OF “BETWEEN”

A homeland visit may produce stronger connection, cultural rediscovery, familiarity, distance, new questions, or generational difference. Research on second-generation Pakistani visits shows that travel can participate in identity renegotiation, but it does not produce one emotional response for every person.⁴ A visit is not the same as permanent return. Diaspora relationships may involve

AUTHENTICITY WITHOUT A RIGID TEST

A person does not automatically become less connected to Orakzai because they live abroad, speak English or another language, wear different clothes, work in a modern profession, have different cultural habits, or were born outside Pakistan. At the same time, heritage claims should not be fabricated. Authenticity is not identical to performance, and a person is not a stereotype.

holidays, weddings, property, business, education, retirement, or return migration. Some people may feel “too foreign” in a homeland setting and/or “too different” in the host society. Others may feel at home in both, neither, or differently depending on the setting. “Between” can become “both,” but this is a possible interpretation, not a universal diaspora experience. Hybrid identity can mean multiple cultural influences becoming one lived identity; it does not mean confusion, falseness, or weakened heritage.

Identity can be inherited, learned, experienced, and chosen. A person may identify as Orakzai, Pashtun, Pakistani, Muslim, British, American, Canadian, Australian, another local identity, or several at once. No single factor should automatically determine another person’s identity. A surname, birthplace, language, appearance, nationality, religion, or family origin cannot by itself determine someone’s current identity. The ethical rule is simple: ask, listen, document scope, and preserve uncertainty.

LOGIC ATLAS: IDENTITY IN THE DIASPORA

These 69 original SVG graphics translate the page’s central reasoning into compact, printable structures. They avoid population counts, rigid authenticity tests, unsupported identity statistics, and the assumption that language, religion, nationality, or surname can determine a person’s identity.

WHAT IS IDENTITY?

PERSON

RELATIONSHIPS

EXPERIENCE

1. What is identity? — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

MULTI-LAYER IDENTITY

PERSONAL

FAMILY / HERITAGE

LOCAL / GLOBAL

2. Multi-layer identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

ORAKZAI IDENTITY

ANCESTRY

FAMILY CONNECTION

PERSONAL CHOICE

3. Orakzai identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

PASHTUN IDENTITY

ORAKZAI

PASHTUN WORLD

SPECIFICITY REMAINS

4. Pashtun identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

PAKISTANI IDENTITY

ORAKZAI

PASHTUN

PAKISTANI

5. Pakistani identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

RELIGIOUS IDENTITY

FAITH

PRACTICE

COMMUNITY

6. Religious identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

HOST-COUNTRY IDENTITY

HERITAGE

CURRENT HOME

MULTIPLE BELONGING

7. Host-country identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

MULTIPLE BELONGING

ORAKZAI

LOCAL SOCIETY

BELONGING

8. Multiple belonging — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

HOMELAND

PLACE OF ORIGIN

FAMILY MEMORY

EMOTIONAL LINK

9. Homeland — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

HOME VS HOMELAND

HOME

LIFE HAPPENS HERE

HOMELAND ≠ ALWAYS HOME

10. Home vs homeland — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

MEMORY

STORY

PHOTOGRAPH

PLACE

11. Memory — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

GRANDPARENTS

ELDER VOICE

FAMILY HISTORY

INTERGENERATIONAL TRANSMISSION

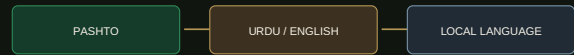
12. Grandparents — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

LANGUAGE IDENTITY



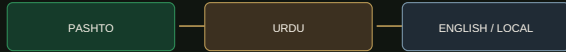
13. Language identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

PASHTO DIASPORA



14. Pashto diaspora — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

CODE-SWITCHING



15. Code-switching — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

LANGUAGE LOSS



16. Language loss — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

LANGUAGE REVIVAL



17. Language revival — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

FOOD IDENTITY



18. Food identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

MUSIC IDENTITY



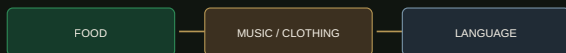
19. Music identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

CLOTHING IDENTITY



20. Clothing identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

VISIBLE CULTURE



21. Visible culture — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

EID IDENTITY



22. Eid identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

WEDDING IDENTITY



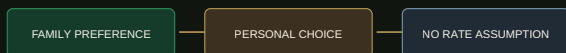
23. Wedding identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

FUNERAL IDENTITY



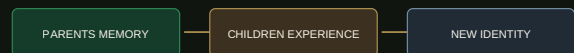
24. Funeral identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

MARRIAGE AND IDENTITY



25. Marriage and identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

SECOND GENERATION



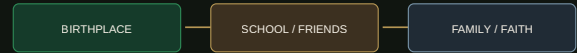
26. Second generation — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

THIRD GENERATION



27. Third generation — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

CHILDREN BORN ABROAD



28. Children born abroad — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

YOUTH IDENTITY



29. Youth identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

WOMEN AND IDENTITY



30. Women and identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

MEN AND IDENTITY



31. Men and identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY



32. Professional identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

EDUCATION



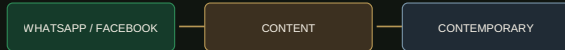
33. Education — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

RELIGION



34. Religion — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

DIGITAL IDENTITY



35. Digital identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

SOCIAL MEDIA



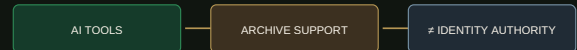
36. Social media — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

DIGITAL PRESERVATION



37. Digital preservation — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

AI AND IDENTITY



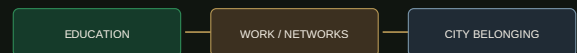
38. AI and identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY AND PLACE



39. Identity and place — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

URBAN IDENTITY



40. Urban identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

HOMELAND VISITS



41. Homeland visits — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

RETURN QUESTION



42. Return question — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

BETWEEN WORLDS



43. Between worlds — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

HYBRID IDENTITY



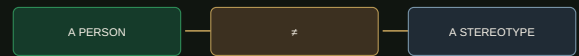
44. Hybrid identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY CHOICE



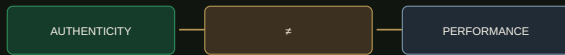
45. Identity choice — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

STEREOTYPES



46. Stereotypes — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

AUTHENTICITY



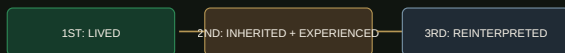
47. Authenticity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

BEING ORAKZAI ABROAD



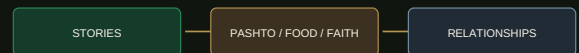
48. Being Orakzai abroad — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY ACROSS GENERATIONS



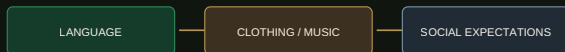
49. Identity across generations — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

WHAT SURVIVES



50. What survives — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

WHAT CHANGES



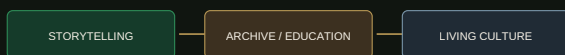
51. What changes — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY LOSS



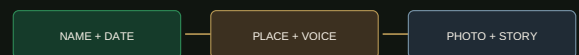
52. Identity loss — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY PRESERVATION



53. Identity preservation — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

MEMORY ARCHIVE



54. Memory archive — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

FAMILY ARCHIVE

IDENTIFY ELDERS

RECORD + SCAN

CONSENT + CONTEXT

55. Family archive — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY RESEARCH

SELF-IDENTIFICATION

EXTERNAL CLASSIFICATION

COMPARE CAREFULLY

56. Identity research — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

EVIDENCE LEVELS

SELF-IDENTIFICATION

FAMILY / ORAL HISTORY

PUBLIC / ACADEMIC

57. Evidence levels — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY EVIDENCE MATRIX

DIMENSION

EVIDENCE

LIMITATION

58. Identity evidence matrix — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY QUESTIONS

WHAT MAKES ME?

WHO SAYS?

NO UNIVERSAL ANSWER

59. Identity questions — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

RESEARCH GAP

COUNTRY

GENERATION

IDENTITY STORIES

60. Research gap — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

ORAL-HISTORY QUESTIONS

ASK

LISTEN

PRESERVE

61. Oral-history questions — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

IDENTITY NETWORK

FAMILY

LANGUAGE / FAITH

PLACE / COMMUNITY

62. Identity network — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

HERITAGE AND HOME

HERITAGE

HOME

MULTIPLE BELONGING

63. Heritage and home — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

LANGUAGE AND IDENTITY

PASHTO

MULTILINGUAL LIFE

IDENTITY NEGOTIATION

64. Language and identity — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

GENERATION DIAGRAM

LIVED MEMORY

INHERITED MEMORY

REINTERPRETED MEMORY

65. Generation diagram — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

MULTIPLE BELONGING DIAGRAM

TRIBE / ETHNICITY

NATION / RELIGION

CITY / PROFESSION

66. Multiple belonging diagram — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

DIGITAL IDENTITY DIAGRAM

REAL LIFE

PLATFORM

SELECTIVE SELF-REPRESENTATION

67. Digital identity diagram — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.

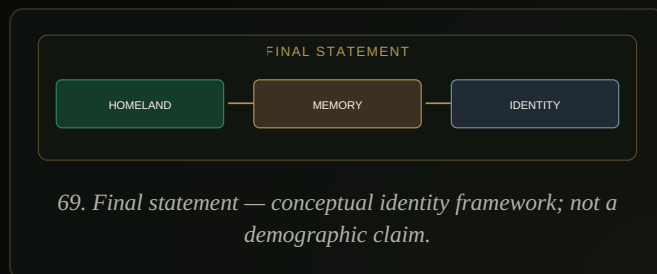
CULTURAL CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CONTINUITY

ADAPTATION

CHANGE ≠ DISAPPEARANCE

68. Cultural continuity and change — conceptual identity framework; not a demographic claim.



IDENTITY AND EVIDENCE

Researchers should distinguish **self-identification** from external classification. A person may say, “I identify as Orakzai,” while a researcher may place that person into a category for a specific study. Both the person’s account and the research context matter. Evidence must match the claim.

IDENTITY DIMENSION	POSSIBLE EVIDENCE	SCOPE	CONFIDENCE	LIMITATION
Orakzai identity	Self-identification, family testimony, village or kin connection	Direct Orakzai where explicit	Contextual	Private testimony may not be generalizable
Pashtun identity	Self-description, language, cultural or organizational participation	Pashtun-wide	Contextual	Pashtun evidence does not establish Orakzai identity
Pakistani identity	Nationality, citizenship, migration history, public self-description	National / diaspora	Contextual	National identity is not tribal identity
Religious identity	Self-description, mosque, Eid, Ramadan, education, family practice	Religious and family context	Contextual	Practice and identity vary; religion is not ethnicity
Language	Reported repertoire, family use, literacy, language learning	Family / community	Contextual	Speaking or not speaking Pashto does not decide identity
Digital identity	Public posts, videos, group participation, archives	Public / platform-specific	Limited	Online representation is selective and privacy-sensitive
Second / third generation	Interviews, family narratives, visits, education, self-description	Study-specific	Qualitative	Generational labels do not predict individual experience

WHAT STILL NEEDS TO BE DOCUMENTED

Country-specific Orakzai identity; first-, second-, and third-generation experiences; Pashto maintenance, shift, multilingualism, and revival; women’s and youth identity; religious identity; marriage patterns; professional and digital identity; homeland visits; return migration; cultural

events; family archives; oral histories; community organizations; identity terminology; self-identification; mixed families; mixed-language households; and intergenerational change.

Most importantly, future research should listen to people describing their own identities rather than deciding in advance what an Orakzai diaspora identity must look like.

ORAL-HISTORY QUESTIONS

1. Where were you born?
2. Where did your parents come from?
3. What does being Orakzai mean to you?
4. Do you identify as Orakzai?
5. Do you identify as Pashtun?
6. Do you identify as Pakistani?
7. How important is religion to your identity?
8. What language did you grow up speaking?
9. Do you speak Pashto?
10. Who taught you Pashto?
11. Do you speak another language at home?
12. What did your grandparents teach you?
13. What stories about Orakzai do you remember?
14. Have you visited Orakzai?
15. What did the visit mean to you?
16. Do you consider Orakzai home?
17. What country do you consider home?
18. Can both be true?
19. What traditions has your family maintained?
20. Which traditions have changed or disappeared?
21. What do you want your children to know?
22. Do your children speak Pashto?
23. How do they describe their identity?
24. Has social media changed your cultural connection?
25. Do you participate in diaspora communities?
26. What role does Eid play in your identity?
27. What role do weddings play?
28. What role do elders play?
29. What does being Orakzai mean to you today?

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Identity is not a passport.

It is not a single word.

It is not something that can always be measured from the outside.

For someone living far from Orakzai, identity may begin with a grandparent's voice. It may continue through a family name, a few Pashto words, a story about a village, a photograph of mountains, an Eid gathering, a wedding, a meal, a journey back home, or simply the feeling that a distant place is somehow part of who you are.

But identity also grows from the life we build: the school we attend, the language we learn, the people we meet, the country where we work, the city where our children are born, and the values we choose.

For me, diaspora identity should not be understood as a choice between two worlds. A person can remember one place and belong to another. A person can carry an ancestral identity and build a new life. A person can speak several languages and still carry the memory of one.

The goal is not to force every Orakzai person into the same definition. The goal is to listen, document, understand, and allow identity to remain human. Culture survives not only when people preserve everything from the past. It survives when people understand what they inherited, decide what matters to them, and carry that meaning forward.

**YOU CAN LIVE FAR FROM YOUR HOMELAND
WITHOUT LIVING FAR FROM YOUR MEMORY.**

REFERENCES AND EVIDENCE NOTES

¹ Robert Nichols, *A History of Pashtun Migration, 1775–2006* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), bibliographic record and description at the [Internet Archive](#). Pashtun-wide historical context; not an Orakzai population or identity survey.

² Amina Khalid, Arshad Ali Khan, and Brian D. Joseph, “Family language policy and identity formation among migrant Pashto community in the multilingual context of Lahore,” *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*, vol. 13, article 1172 (2026), [doi:10.1057/s41599-026-07534-z](#). The sample concerns migrant Pashto speakers in Lahore; it is comparative evidence, not direct Orakzai diaspora evidence.

³ Zeeshan Rafiq and Susan Dunnett, “The inter-generational construction of religious in/authenticity in the rituals of British Pakistani Muslims,” *Journal of Marketing Management*, vol. 25, no. 1, pp. 35–55 (2024), [doi:10.1177/14705931231226121](#). British Pakistani evidence on three generations and religious/ethnic negotiation; not direct Orakzai evidence.

⁴ The homeland-visit discussion is framed as a research question supported by comparative British Pakistani and South Asian diaspora scholarship, not as a universal causal claim. Page 97’s overseas context and Page 98’s global-community evidence are internal book cross-references, not substitutes for Orakzai-specific identity studies.

⁵ José C. Moya, “Immigrants and Associations: A Global and Historical Perspective,” *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, vol. 31, no. 5, pp. 833–864 (2005), [doi:10.1080/13691830500178147](#). Used for comparative understanding of immigrant associations and formal/informal sociability; not an Orakzai-specific source.

⁶ Page 99 uses public individual records only as bounded examples. A named person’s public activity cannot establish a global Orakzai identity pattern, organization, or population count. No unsupported identity statistic, marriage rate, language-retention percentage, community size, or generational survey is presented.